Making Exhibitions as We Research Through Art: The Exhibition Operations Kit

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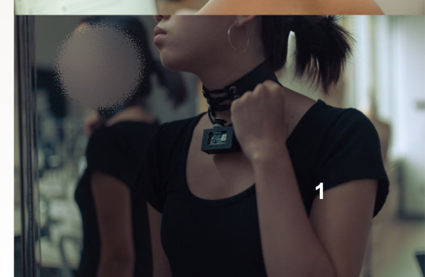

Abstract

Research Through Art is establishing artistic practice as a legitimate mode of inquiry, yet the operational work of exhibition-making remains under-articulated. While exhibitions are frequently used to present research-based artworks, they are often treated as outcomes rather than as structured research environments shaped by curatorial decisions. Building on the Research Through Art method, we combine first-person reflection and annotated portfolio to articulate a set of modular components that structure how such exhibitions are designed, staged, and encountered. Illustrated through a case study, *Perversion of Interfaces*—an exhibition of research based critical objects—we present basic operational modules for exhibition-based research output. These modules include shared curatorial prompts, interpretation layers, spatial and experiential planning, peripheral exhibition artifacts, public programming, and post-exhibition reflection. We hope this transferable framework can support educators and curators to present work as exhibitions and to develop modular toolkits for organizing art shows.

Authors Keywords

Curation, Design, Annotated Portfolio, Exhibition Design, Research though Art, Community-based Curatorial Practice

CCS Concepts

▪ Human-centered computing~Interaction design process and methods

Introduction

Exhibitions have become an increasingly important format through which design, art, and Human Computer Interaction (HCI) communities present, encounter, and discuss practice-based work. In this pictorial we examine exhibition-making as an operational research practice, analysing *Perversion of Interfaces*—a research-based critical objects exhibition—to derive a set of modular curatorial operations that form an *Exhibition Operations Kit*.

The model of exhibition has been adapted by art-technology education practitioners and researchers [6, 9, 13, 32, 45]. In design and art programs, exhibitions commonly extend student work beyond the classroom and into public view. In public showcases, exhibitions are used to mark completion, celebrate outcomes, and make student projects visible to broader audiences (e.g. [59], [10]). These exhibitions can be brought into academic discourse a lens that positions artistic practice as a mode of inquiry where knowledge is generated through making, staging, and public encounters – Research Through Art (RtA) [12, 13, 16]. Within RtA traditions, exhibitions frequently serve as moments where artistic research becomes visible, sharable, and

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open to interpretation. Exhibitions are often discussed as sites of meaning-making, reflection, or audience engagement, and are commonly practiced through collaborative effort between artists and researchers [1, 26, 40].

This issue resonates with ongoing discussions in the HCI community around alternative research outputs [28, 34, 58]. Beyond paper and poster presentation, practice-based work is more and more experienced spatially, materially, and collectively in HCI. While it is hard to trace when do ACM conferences started to host artworks (likely originated by ACM/SIGGRAPH with computer graphics art [60]), ACM conferences have incorporated artistic practice alongside traditional research over many years. The growing presence of art tracks and exhibition-based submissions in HCI conferences reflects this lineage and an increasing recognition of artistic practice as a research contribution.

The growing emphasis on creativity and interdisciplinary practice has led to increased focus on generalist skill sets and cross-disciplinary modes of making within higher education [8, 43]. The broader shifts in interdisciplinary education and research have intensified the conditions under which such exhibitions are produced. In these contexts, distinctions between artist, designer, researcher, student, and curator are increasingly blurred. For example, researchers may also be practitioners, and students may contribute research-based work. As a result, exhibitions may simultaneously serve pedagogical, artistic, and scholarly purposes.

Prior RtA work has examined collaboration between researchers and artists. However, less attention has been paid to contexts in which these roles overlap—where researchers are also artists, educators, and curators (e.g [41, 55])—and where exhibitions function not as venues for presenting research, but as shared research environments. This research gap causes the lack of articulated curatorial operations in HCI communities, inhibiting exhibition methods as research practice to be reused, critiqued, or built upon.

New media Exhibition processes are fun because they present unique curatorial opportunities and challenges. For instance, an earlier project on pop-up participatory exhibitions has explored how exhibitions can be integrated into design and ideation processes [50]. Exhibition tech studies show how curator can successfully communicate curatorial visions through emerging technologies [27, 57]. Postdigital museum scholarship further emphasizes that exhibitions operate as assemblages of spatial, technological, and organizational decisions through which meaning is enacted, rather than as neutral containers for content [36]. Yet the operational practices that enable exhibitions to function as research remain under-articulated, even though many artistic outputs from HCI research projects are new media works that are interactive and participatory. Unlike traditional static fine art pieces (e.g., paintings, prints, static sculptures, etc), these works add additional difficulties in curation. For example, curators must ensure electricity supply, arrange power plugs, and maintain the exhibits. These technical complexities require extra consideration beyond making a cohesive narrative for presenting research outputs within a physical space [37].

In this pictorial, we examine exhibition-making as an operational research practice within RtA, building on recent work that frames exhibitions themselves as sites of inquiry, such as Exhibit-Based Research [14]. We analyzed *Perversion of Interfaces* – an research-based critical objects exhibition as a case study of community-based curatorial practice. We used S1's first-person curatorial reflections and the annotated portfolio method to complete the analysis. We frame the exhibition as a constituency that brings together human and non-human actors, and show how care labor played a central role in sustaining collaboration and lowering barriers to participation throughout the process. From these reflections, we derive a set of exhibition operation modules that articulate how exhibitions are designed, staged, encountered, and reflected upon. We present these modules as an *Exhibition Operations Kit*—a practical, flexible framework for artist-researchers, designer-researchers, educators, and curators collaborating in contexts where roles overlap and exhibitions function simultaneously as research, pedagogical, and community interfaces.

About the Team and Positionality

All authors participated in *Perversion of Interfaces* as members of a shared research and curatorial community. The authors worked across overlapping positions as artists, researchers, students, educators, and curators. This entanglement of roles is a constitutive condition of exhibition-based Research Through Art. S1 is a researcher and curator. S1 led the organization of the exhibition and brought prior experience in community-based curatorial practice. S1's long-term curatorial practice and reflections form a primary source for the analytic autoethnography presented in this pictorial. S2, S3, and S4 are researchers-artists/designers who have work exhibited in Perversion of Interfaces and participated actively in the curatorial process. Their dual position as exhibitors and co-curators shaped how exhibition concepts were articulated, revised, and materialized through design decisions, spatial arrangements, and peripheral artifacts. S5 contributed to curatorial and design assistance throughout the exhibition process without contributing as an artist. S5's distance from the pieces provided valuable insights and objectivity into the interpretation of the show. S6 is the director of the research lab in which the exhibition took place and contributed both an exhibited work and curatorial input. The exhibition originated from S6's investigating prototype and continuous mentorship to all the other authors.

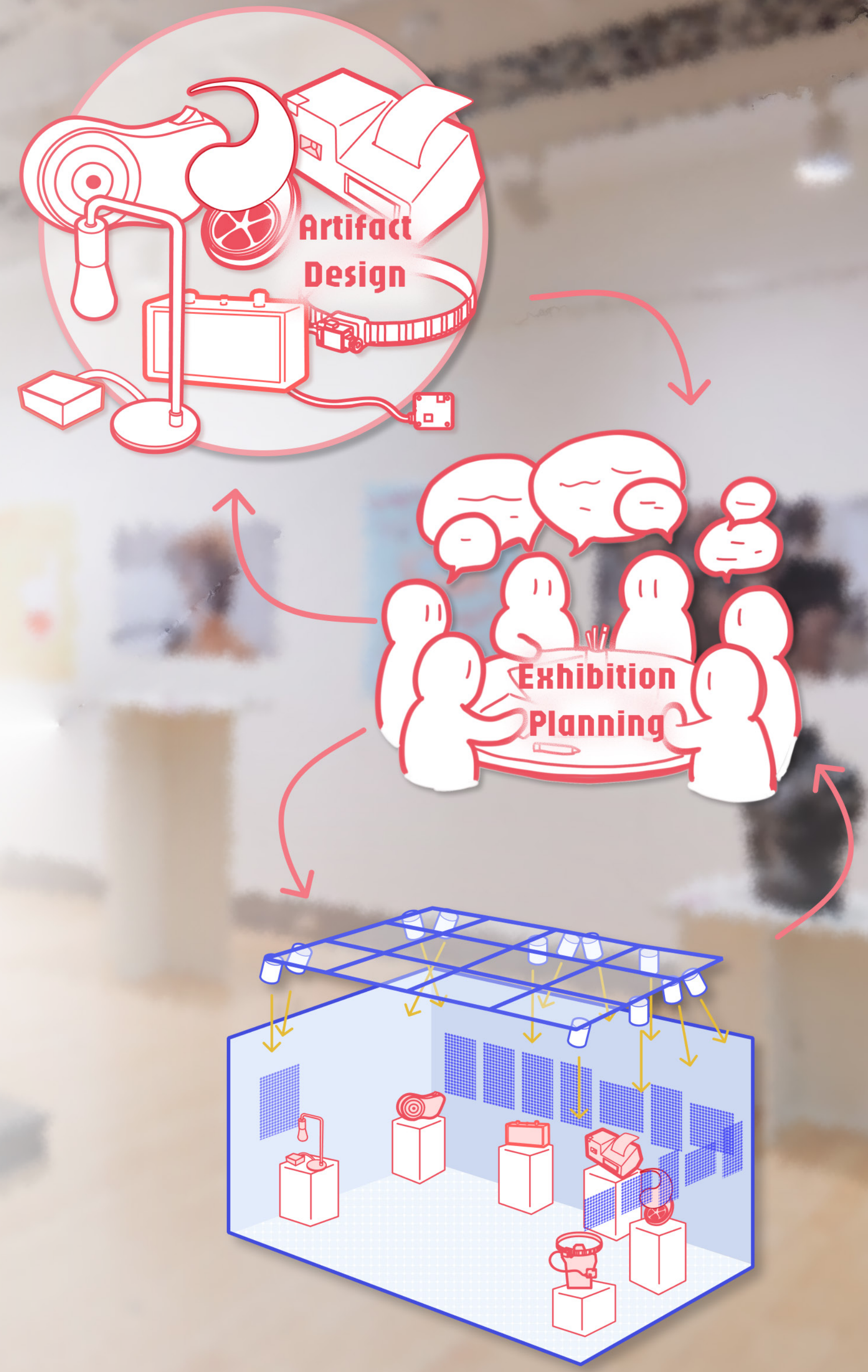
Method: Annotating Our Curatorial Practice

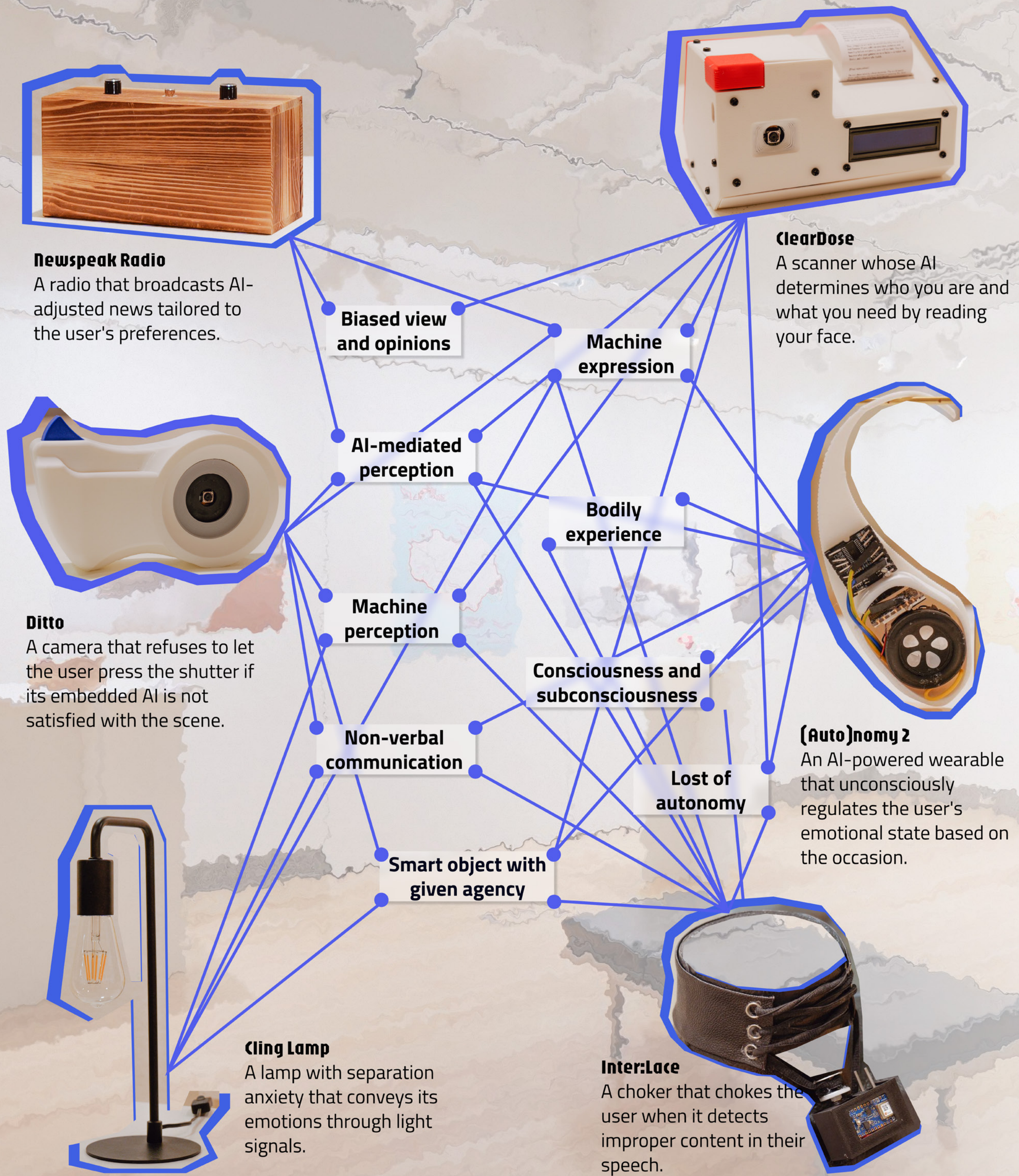
With the annotated portfolio approach [5], we annotate the visual documentation to unfold and illustrate our considerations in executing this exhibition, followed by curator S1's reflections on their curatorial practice. Annotated portfolios "bring together individual artifacts as a systematic body of work," and present multiple conceptual perspectives to read the designs [5, 18]. Therefore, the method allows us to orient how the art pieces talk to each other, how the collection is understood by audiences, and how our execution invites engagement. Such an approach is effective in showcasing abstract and latent ideas behind artifacts and their relationship with the user [17, 21].

More specifically, we annotate our collaborative curatorial process to showcase how we made this exhibition happen in the spirit of community engagement within our research lab. We see exhibitions as spatialized annotated portfolios — platforms that instantiate an annotated portfolio in spatial, temporal, and embodied form. Yet the curatorial logic of an exhibition often remains invisible to the audiences. Curatorial considerations around placement, sequencing, lighting, and movement that shape how works are encountered are neither obvious to the audience physically present nor accessible merely through reading the visual documentation. To this end, our annotations aim to complement and enrich the visual material to show the "back stage" of our exhibition *Perversion of Interfaces*, illustrating how we navigate technical obstacles for presenting new media works, make design decisions, maintain lab members' participation, and weave the works into a coherent narrative.

Beyond documenting the curatorial process, we also attend to how the exhibition space itself participates in meaning-making. To do this, we annotate the intra-actions of the elements within the exhibition space. Intra-action refers to the idea that entities emerge within relations rather than prior to them [15]. The meaning of an exhibition is produced through curation, a material-discursive practice in which placement, sequencing, lighting, and movement shape how works are encountered. In other words, the narrative and experience of our exhibition co-emerge with the elements through these spatial relations. In our pictorial, we highlight how works and their meanings are constituted through space, ultimately enacting our exhibition *Perversion of Interfaces*.

Lastly, informed by our curation process, we present an *Exhibition Operation Kit*. The modules in the kit are identified by reflecting on what happened during exhibition-making. By treating the exhibition itself as analytic material, we reflected upon planning, installation, interpretation, and post-exhibition discussion to identify recurring curatorial operations, which were later abstracted into the modular components presented in this pictorial.





Forming Collective meanings

Our exhibition theme *Perversion* was not predefined, but emerged when we put all the artworks together. Those artifacts speak to each other through shared themes and subject matter. These connections constitute and enrich the theme *Perversion*. All the works can be considered as smart objects while sharing a critical nature that resists techno-solutionism [31, 42]; instead of designing for efficiency and productivity, they offer alternative ways for humans to relate with AI systems.

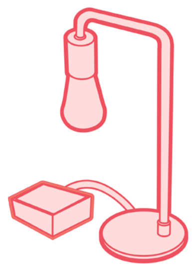
Beyond this overarching narrative, each work touches on a few themes among bias in machine learning, machine expression, AI mediated perception, embodied experience, machine perception, consciousness and subconsciousness, non-verbal communication, autonomy, and smart objects. For example, *ClearDose* scans the user's face and outputs a fortune-telling prescription based on the AI's interpretation of the user's identity and needs through their facial features [20]. *Inter:Lace* chokes the user when the AI embedded in the device detects improper content in their speech [7]. Both devices require users to give up a certain level of agency: the *Inter:Lace* user outsources their self-regulation to the device, while the *ClearDose* user may uncritically trust the AI-generated prescription. Moreover, the user is unable to press *Ditto* camera's shutter if the embedded AI is not satisfied with the scene; *Cling Lamp* communicates its intention through blinks that are impossible for the user to fully grasp. *Inter:Lace*, *Ditto*, and *Cling Lamp* communicate with the user non-verbally and have been given agency to act. *(Auto)nomy2* quietly regulates the wearer's emotional states; *Newspeak Radio* adjusts its content to tailor users' preferences and interests. Their users' perceptions of the world are mediated by these devices.

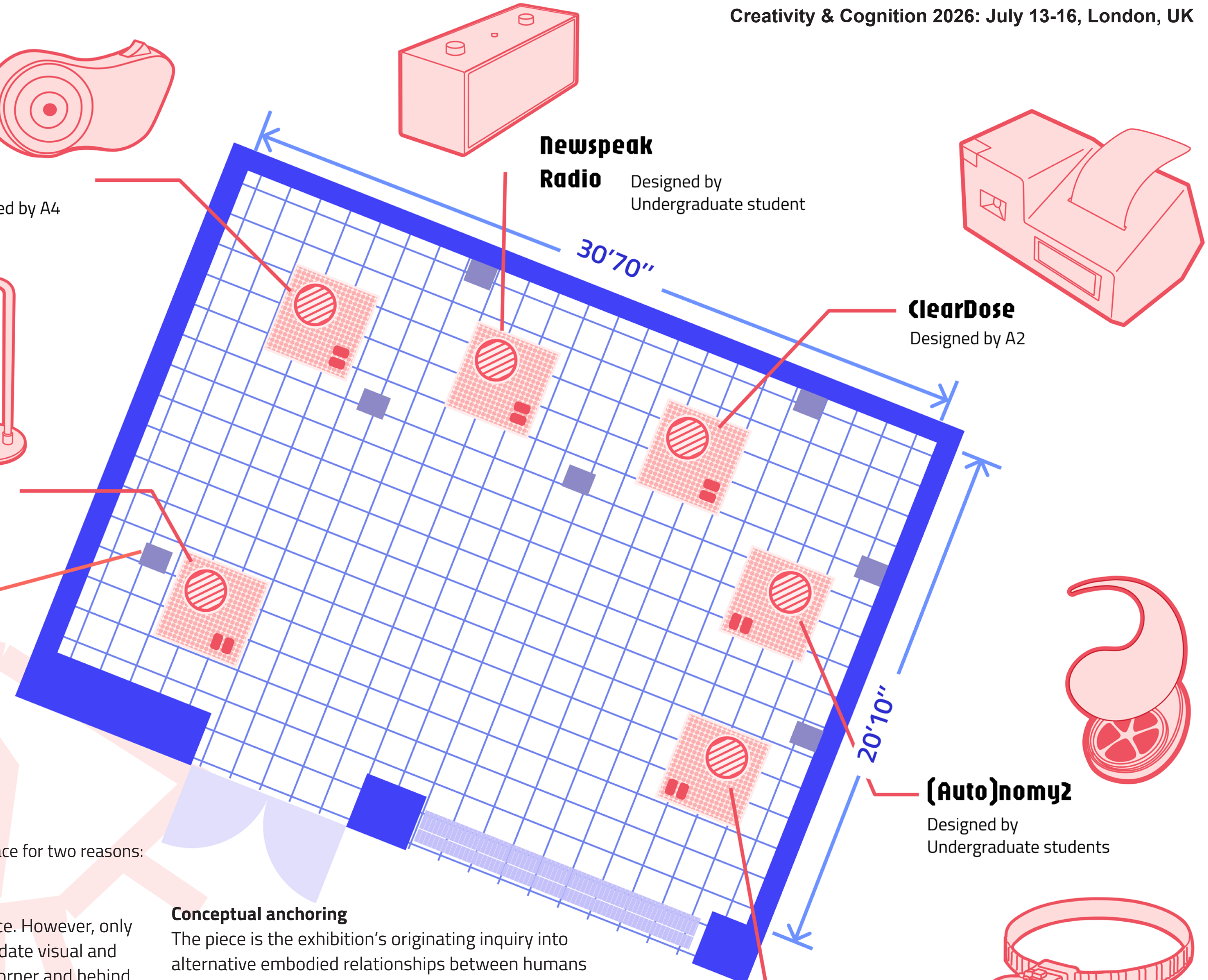
Overall, reading these artworks together adds layers of narratives and enacts the theme *Perversion*. The interpretations of each work are not fixed but porous and dynamic as they enter into relation with others in the exhibition space. Collectively, these artworks constellate a critique of the role of AI in reality and offer speculations about alternative ways humans and AI systems could relate.

Spatial Planning

In this page, we annotated how the exhibit space is arranged for the exhibition.

- Power Outlet
- Glass
- Exhibition pedestal
- Door
- Wall
- Piece
- Peripheral Artifact





Experience Planning: Placement Consideration

S6's piece is placed at the entry of the space for two reasons:

Spatial Experience Planning
There are a couple of outlets in the space. However, only the one at the entry can best accommodate visual and movement needs as the cord is in the corner and behind a pedestal.

Conceptual anchoring
The piece is the exhibition's originating inquiry into alternative embodied relationships between humans and LLM agents. Encountering this piece first establishes a conceptual reference point that helps visitors orient subsequent works within the exhibition's broader investigation.

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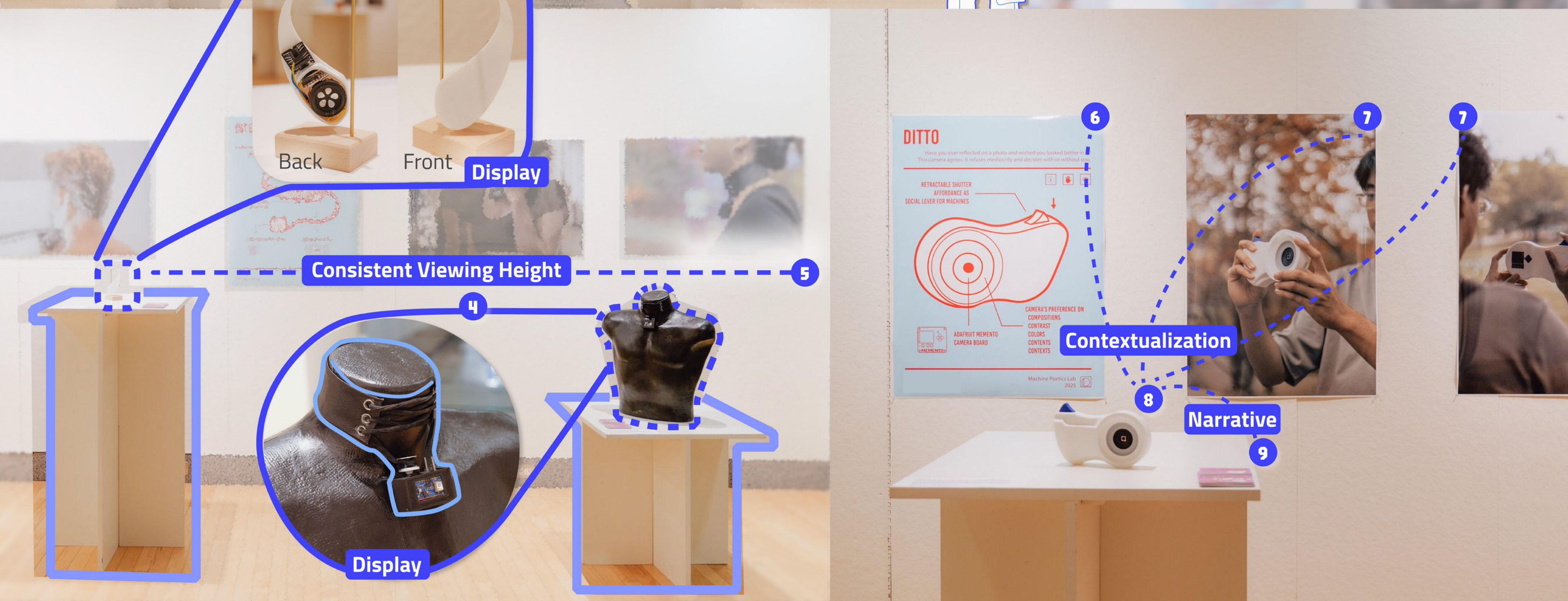
In this page, we annotate our exhibition setup to reveal our curatorial considerations and demonstrate the intra-action between the elements.

1. Poster Lighting
2. Art Work Lighting
3. Small jewelry stand for best display and context
4. Mannequin for best display and context
5. To maintain a consistent viewing height for the exhibits and ensure an optimal viewing experience, we opted for black mannequins with a more suitable height. However, this choice has resulted in the exhibits not being as prominently displayed.
6. Poster to provide technical & conceptual detail
7. Photos to contextualize piece in real life
8. The piece
9. Coupons supporting the exhibition narratives.



Poster Design

Each piece is accompanied by its own poster designed for visual communication. The posters are intentionally positioned as peripheral artifacts that contextualize the technical and conceptual dimensions of each work without competing with the physical encounter. By separating technical description from the object itself, the posters allow audiences to engage with the works experientially first, while offering a background interpretative layer for those who seek additional context.

In addition to the individual posters, the exhibition includes a master poster that operates at the scale of public programming. This poster communicates exhibition information and announces the closing event, situating the show within a broader public-facing frame. Together, the individual and master posters form a distributed visual communication system that supports interpretation at multiple levels while preserving the autonomy of each piece.

See the individual poster in Appendix B.

Coupon Cards as Peripheral and Artifacts

The coupon cards were designed for *Perversion of Interfaces* for two related reasons. First, they function as **keepsakes that extend engagement beyond the exhibition space**, allowing the exhibition to persist after the physical visit. By taking a coupon with them, audiences carry a fragment of the exhibition's language, imagery, and logic into other contexts.

Second, the coupons support **onsite audience engagement** by adopting the visual and rhetorical form of small commercial advertisements. Distributed casually within the gallery, the cards invite audiences to interpret them using familiar logics of advertising, promotion, and consumption – the visual narrative derived from an earlier Interpretation Layer. In doing so, audiences take on an active role in context-setting, negotiating whether the coupons are promotional material, satire, or speculative propositions.

See the individual coupon in Appendix C.

Discussion

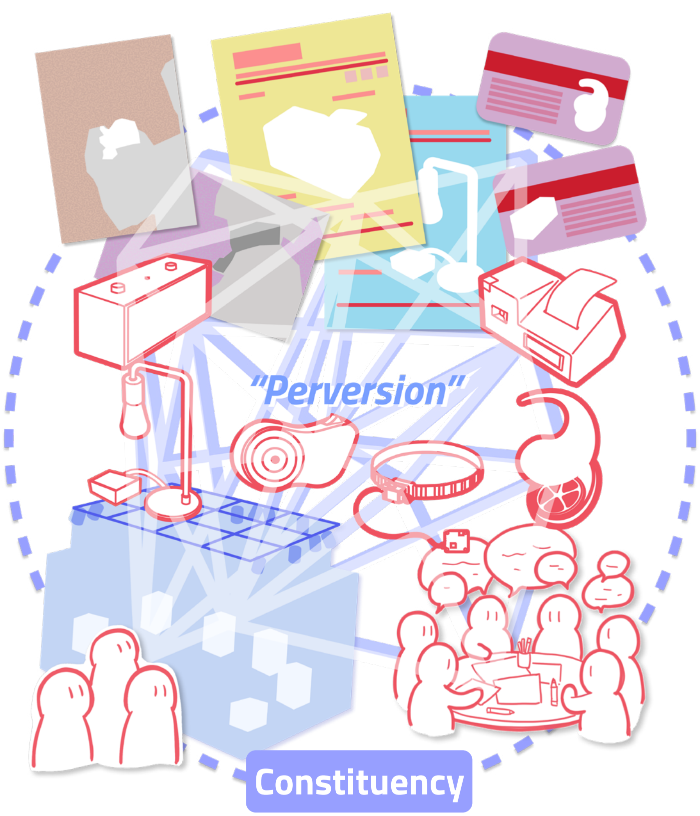
Community Based Curatorial Works

S1 describes their curatorial practice as community-based. In this pictorial, community-based refers to curating as a relational practice that forms and supports community through the process of exhibition-making. This may take place within an existing community, but it may also emerge among people who come together through the exhibition itself. In either case, curatorial work helps structure collaboration, distribute decision-making, and support the collective negotiation of meaning over time. It also extends outward through audience outreach and participatory programming, creating ways for people beyond the immediate exhibition-making group to encounter and enter the exhibition's inquiry. In this sense, community-based curatorial work is not limited to selecting and presenting finished objects for an external public [37].

In *Perversion of Interfaces*, the curating community is the research lab whose members hold varying levels of expertise and familiarity with exhibition-making. Undergraduate students, graduate students, and the principal investigator all contributed works that functioned simultaneously as artistic experiments and research artifacts. This varying expertise and experience level is a core condition of the community-based curatorial practice. This practice focused on building an inclusive environment in which participants could shape the exhibition's development, interpretation, and presentation [30]. Within this process, S1's curatorial labor centered on creating conditions for collective articulation. By resisting fixed categorizations of participants' roles, the curatorial process treated difference as productive, enabling a "hybridity of many sorts" through which varied, and sometimes conflicting, interpretations could emerge [25].

Community Based Curatorial Works (continued)

This community-based curatorial practice relied heavily on process-level artifacts. Meeting notes, exhibition text descriptions, posters, and peripheral materials were all created in shared documents and used not merely to document progress but to hold them open for revision and collective interpretation. These artifacts functioned as shared infrastructure that allowed audience participants to enter curatorial conversations at different moments and from different positions. In the process of curating for *Perversion of Interfaces*, S1 used these materials to externalize decision-making and make curatorial operations visible and negotiable for everyone. S1's role embodied a practice of overt-implicit care: they lowered the barriers of curatorial practice to ensure the engagement of less experienced members, thereby maintaining the sense of community [52].



Interpretation was similarly treated as a collective and ongoing process. Instead of producing a definitive curatorial statement early on, interpretation emerged through repeated discussions, rewrites, and material translations—such as the decision to adopt commercial narratives across works. This allowed participants to test ideas through design choices and observe how those choices shaped the exhibition's inquiry. Curatorial work operated as a form of facilitation that supported shared sense-making within the community that is involved in curation. For this reason, the authors' positionality and division of labor is never clearly articulated in this pictorial, as we view our curation process as a collective endeavor [49].

Community-based curatorial practice also shaped how the exhibition reached beyond the immediate exhibition-making group because it views exhibitions produced under the practice as an outreach branch for the communities. This means this practice often considers the public engagement as part of the exhibition process. It especially serves the HCI community because the exhibited works are usually research-based critical objects with technical and conceptual complexity. Community-based curatorial methods helped translate that complexity into forms that visitors could approach from different positions.

In Perversion of Interface, the curation is actively considered for public encounters to serve the purpose of extending the community. The commercial framing offered a familiar public language through which visitors could begin engaging the works. Posters and exhibition texts provided additional technical and conceptual context for clarification. Peripheral artifacts such as coupon cards built the commercial framing and extended the exhibition's logic beyond the gallery itself, allowing visitors to carry fragments of its language and framing into later encounters. Public programming created occasions for discussion, reflection, and temporary participation in the exhibition's inquiry. Through these layered invitations, the exhibition then allowed participants to contribute meaning-making as well as peeking into the lab's practice for more conversations and potential future collaborations – and hence growing the community.

We see the community-based curatorial practice as a *Labor of Care*. Feminist care scholarship emphasizes that care is relational, situated, and infrastructural. Joan Tronto's foundational definition frames care as "everything that we do to maintain, continue and repair our world so that we can live in it as well as possible" [53]. María Puig de la Bellacasa extends this by describing care as a "situated and committed form of speculation" that at once sustains existing worlds and opens them to new constituencies and political stakes [11]. Tove Pettersen's elaboration of "mature care" emphasises that care is a relational and reciprocal process in which both carer and care-receiver participate [38, 39]. Community-based curatorial work embodies these thoughts on labor of care. On top of this, community-based curation functions as maintenance. Steven Jackson's "broken world thinking" that the work of repair and upkeep is generative and care-centric [23]. In community-based curatorial practice, curatorial care involves this kind of maintenance work: sustaining a collective of people, artifacts, and interpretations, repairing gaps in knowledge or confidence, and ensuring that participation and involvement could continue over time. This practice highlights care not only as inclusion but as ongoing repair of the relationships and infrastructures that make community-based exhibitions possible.

Exhibition as a constituency

Our exhibition emerged from the collaboration between designer-researchers, the curator, the gallery space, lighting, exhibits, exhibition pedestals, power outlets, posters, speculative coupons, and visitors. All of these, following Wakkary, were gathered by the curatorial prompt to convene a constituency—an assembly of human and nonhuman things [56]. In this sense, the design team, instead of merely the curator S1, became the speaking subjects of this constituency [51]. As the speaking subject, we gather and engage non-humans into this constituency through arranging the space, making peripheral artifacts, adjusting lighting, and crafting narratives. This constituency is dynamic and ever-changing [51]. For example, shared docs and instant messaging apps were temporarily present in this constituency when the design team was iterating the narrative; posters and coupons became a part of this constituency after they were made; audiences enter this constituency and temporally served as speaking subject when they experience the exhibition and engage in the interpretation and sense-making process. The speaking subject in this constituency enacts the agency of non-humans [56]. Therefore, the meaning and experience of this exhibition emerged through the intra-action within the constituency. For example, multiple themes emerged through the encounter of the exhibits, allowing multiple interpretations [46]; the spotlight invited the exhibits and posters to stand out. Additionally, the peripheral artifacts contextualized the exhibits, situated them within a commercial advertisement context, and unfolded the *"perverted"* aspects of the exhibits, staging them as critiques of the mainstream smart object design and resisting techno-solutionism [3, 31, 42].

For human designers, acting as the speaking subject requires them to recognize the shared agency between humans and non-humans, giving rise to humility [56]. In our case, the diverse levels of experience in curation, design, and research meant that no single member held complete authority. This encouraged the design team members (as speaking subjects) to "act from not knowing or practical knowing", remaining open and attentive to each other, and to the non-human actors in the constituency [35, 56]. This humility allowed overlapping narratives to emerge beyond explicit human intention and participation.

Staying open with a sense of humility also means embracing all the more-than-human encounters, including the less-desirable ones [51]. Within the mesh of relations in the constituency, disturbance is inevitable [35, 54]. Take the black mannequin we employed as an example: while it ensured that all exhibits were displayed at the same height, it also shaded the *Inter:Lace* due to their shared color. This disturbance shapes the meaning of both actors and reveals the internal negotiations within the constituency: we (as speaking subject) decided to prioritize the collective exhibition experience over the visibility of a single object, demonstrating how meaning and value are negotiated among all constituents rather than predetermined by humans alone. Viewing the exhibition as a constituency highlights how the meaning of each element is shaped by its relationship with the others; every encounter has the potential to alter that meaning [15]. The theme *Perversion* was not fully formed when it entered the exhibition — it emerged through intra-actions between human and non-humans. Therefore, the theme is porous and dynamic, resisting a stable meaning.

Why make the operation kit?

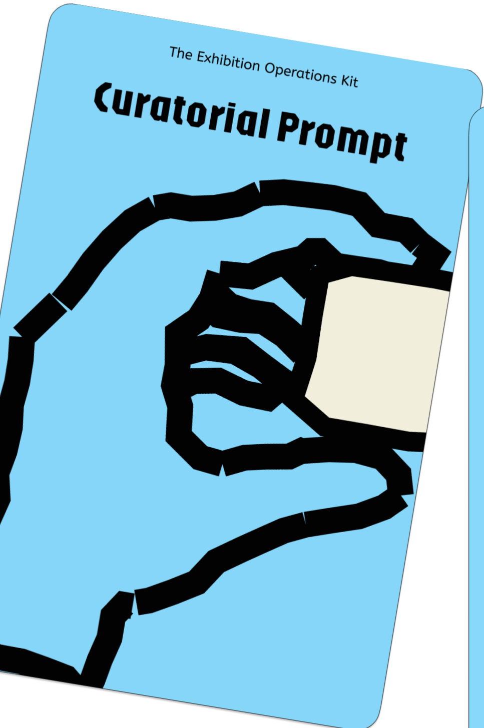
Informed by new media art curatorial practice theories [4, 37], the *Exhibition Operations Kit* is intentionally designed to distribute curatorial labor across multiple roles instead of establishing collaborative relationships between distinctly divided labor identities. This design choice is deduced from the authors' experience in making *Perversion of Interfaces* and S1's previous curatorial practices. The design choice also reflects the conditions under which exhibition-based research increasingly takes place, particularly within interdisciplinary and academic contexts where distinctions between artist, researcher, student, educator, and curator are often blurred. In *Perversion of Interfaces*, participants occupied multiple positions simultaneously: artists were also researchers, students contributed research-based works, and curatorial decisions emerged through collective discussion rather than top-down authorship.

Additionally, following feminist care ethics, we see exhibition-making itself as an ongoing practice of maintenance and mutual support. As a result, most modules in the kit are not addressed to a single role with specific to-dos. Instead, each module requires collective articulation and negotiation. Modules such as Interpretation Layer, Experience Planning, and Post-Exhibition Reflection are explicitly framed as collaborative processes that unfold over time, rather than as tasks to be completed by a designated curator. This reflects our observation that exhibition-making as research depends on shared responsibility and distributed decision-making, especially when exhibitions function as collaborative and research environments rather than as professionalized and commercial art-world productions.

Taking inspiration from the existing open access toolkits [22, 33, 61], designing the modules in the operational kit is also the attempt to make curatorial operations more legible and transferable. By externalizing curatorial decisions into named components, the kit allows participants to step into curatorial roles temporarily and situationally. Anyone involved in the exhibition—artists, researchers, students, or organizers—can activate a module, propose revisions, or surface tensions. This flexibility supports exhibition-making as a form of Research Through Art in which inquiry emerges through collective practice rather than through individual authorship.

At the same time, the *Exhibition Operations Kit* explicitly includes audiences as active participants in the research process. Prior work in HCI and exhibition studies has examined how audiences contribute to meaning-making, participation, and value co-creation in exhibition contexts, emphasizing visitor engagement and interaction as central to exhibition meaning [6, 24, 26, 50]. These studies demonstrate that audiences actively interpret, respond to, and extend exhibitions through their encounters. Building on these studies, we also draw from Free Design ideologies, which frame participation not merely as engagement with a finished artifact but as involvement in an open design process. Free Design positions "everybody" as capable of acting as designers of their own conditions of living and emphasizes design processes that are open to indiscriminate participation [19, 48]. When applied to exhibition contexts, this perspective shifts audience participation from interpretive response toward situational co-design[44], where audiences contribute to meaning-making, contextual framing, and the ongoing life of the exhibition.

Lastly, the making of the *Exhibition Operation Kit* is informed by open design [2, 47] and open collaboration [29]. These frameworks emphasize openness across the entire design process, including documentation, decision-making, the circulation of intermediate knowledge, and collaboration beyond original creations. Within the open frameworks, openness is enacted through participation, porous boundaries between expert and non-expert roles, and the public availability of process-level artifacts. All of the reasons and benefits behind open design and open collaboration are the integral reasons for us to make the *Exhibition Operation Kit.*



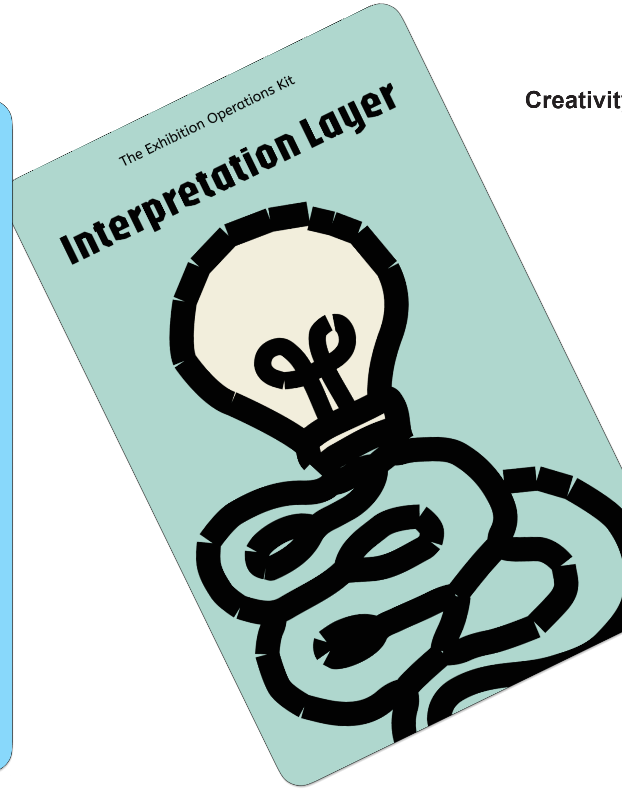
The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
Curatorial prompts may be developed individually or collectively. It can emerge before works are produced or be articulated retrospectively from an existing body of work. While it often appears early in exhibition planning, it may be revised as the exhibition takes shape.

What it does
Establishes a shared inquiry that connects works without prescribing outcomes.

Guiding questions
- What question, tension, or condition connects these works?
- What is explicitly included or excluded?
- Who is the prompt written for: artists, audiences, or both?

Curatorial Prompt



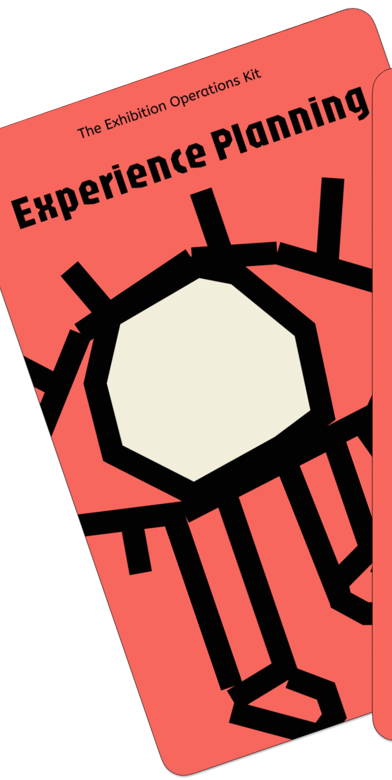
The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
Interpretations are collective and iterative. Artists, curators, researchers, installers, audiences, (essentially all participants) may contribute to interpretation-making at multiple moments throughout the exhibition lifecycle.

What it does
Shapes how meaning is scaffolded without fixing interpretation.

Guiding questions
- How do the decisions enhance or weaken the exhibition's inquiry?
- What contextual information is necessary, and what should remain open?
- Where does interpretation live: text, space, interaction, or instruction?

Interpretation Layer



The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
This process is collective and unfolds across planning stages, both before and after an exhibition site is identified. Experience planning continues as spatial constraints, technical conditions, and audience behaviors become known.

What it does
Designs the temporal, spatial, and sensory sequence of encounter.

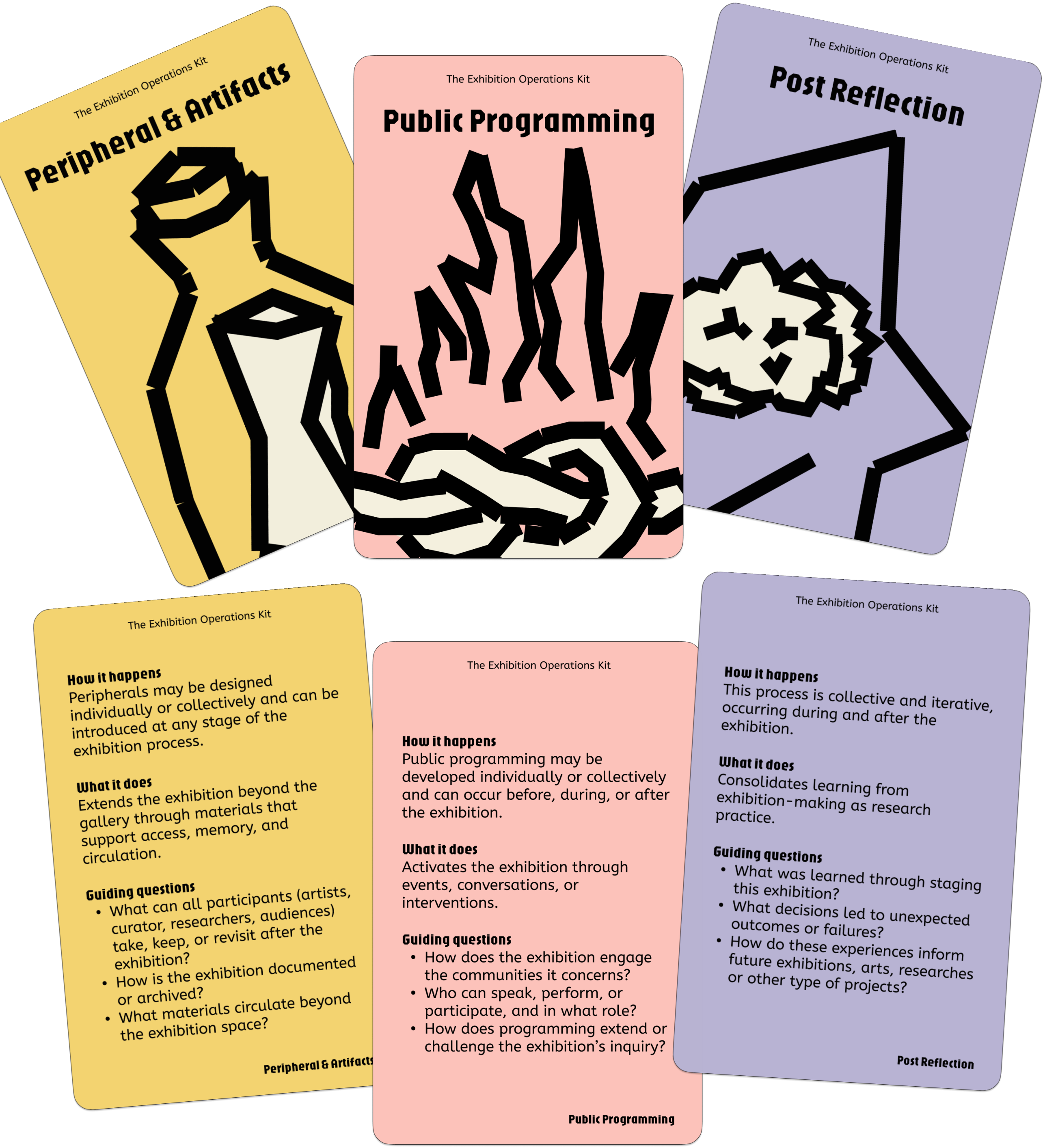
Guiding questions
- Who is experiencing the exhibition, at what time, under what conditions?
- What actions, movements, or pauses happen in the exhibition?
- How do space, timing, and interaction shape the experience?

Experience Planning

How to use the modules in the Exhibition Operations Kit?

The **Exhibition Operations Kit** is designed as a modular research apparatus for exhibition-making. The cards are not intended to prescribe a fixed workflow or ideal exhibition structure. Instead, they support reflective and iterative decision-making by making curatorial operations explicit and negotiable. The kit may be used individually or collectively. In collaborative settings, participants can use the cards as prompts for discussion, planning, and reflection, drawing attention to aspects of exhibition-making that are often handled implicitly. Cards may be introduced at different stages of the exhibition lifecycle and revisited as conditions change.

Take Perversion of Interfaces as an example: The initial impetus for the exhibition emerged from a design project in which a large language model (LLM) operated a lamp. During the development of this project, S6 became interested in alternative forms of embodied interaction between humans and LLM. This curiosity functioned as an initial curatorial prompt, which S6 shared with the rest of the authors and the other participating artists, leading to the decision to organize an exhibition. After securing a gallery space and completing several works, the group collectively discussed and articulated the common threads connecting the pieces that is an interpretation layer. Meeting notes from these discussions were documented by S1 and circulated as part of the exhibition's evolving materials, functioning as peripheral artifacts that tracked the exhibition's development. After reading S1's description, the group decided to adopt commercial language and visual conventions across the works to clarify the exhibition's inquiry for public audiences' experience.



Artists rewrote descriptions of their pieces using this commercial framing, and S1 designed accompanying posters that reinforced this communicative strategy. S5 further extended the exhibition experience by designing a set of commercial-style coupons that visitors could take away, combining experience planning with peripheral artifacts. During installation, works were arranged according to both narrative relationships and the logistical constraints of the space to best consider audiences' experience. The exhibition concluded with a public closing event in which artists and audience members discussed the positioning and implications of the works, activating public programming as a site of reflection. Following the exhibition, the authors conducted interviews with one another to reflect on the process and outcomes, supporting post-exhibition reflection as an ongoing research practice.

As illustrated above, several modules were revisited and used at different moments, particularly the Interpretation Layer, Experience Planning, and Post Reflection. The key is that the card modules are designed to be used non-linearly. Some modules may be emphasized while others are minimized. In some cases, a card may surface tensions or contradictions that require revisiting earlier decisions. This non-linear use reflects the reality of exhibition-making as a research practice, where inquiry evolves through making, staging, and encounter.

Acknowledgement

We acknowledge the human and more-than-human actors that constituted Perversion of Interfaces and this paper. Technician Jaden Jaynes Demarest made the exhibition possible. Margaret Tsai's photographed and documented the exhibition that we annotated on in this pictorial. Yingjie Mu, Yibo Wang, Jiawen Yao, Yumeng Zhuang, Aaron Pengyu Zhu, and the reviewers provided valuable feedback on this pictorial writing. We thank the objects, materials, pedestal, electricity, lights, and software that maintained and sustained the works; the visitors who carried fragments of the exhibition into other contexts and their personal lives; and the Indigenous land of the **Gayogo̱hó:nǫʔ** (the Cayuga Nation) on which we worked and grew.

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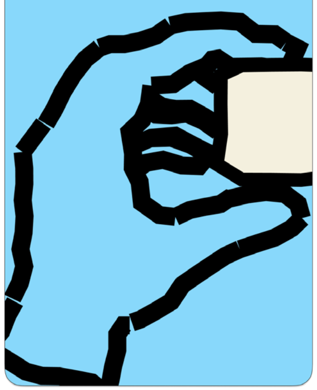
Appendix A: The Exhibition Operation Kit for Print

The Exhibition Operations Kit

Curatorial Prompt



The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
Curatorial prompts may be developed individually or collectively. It can emerge before works are produced or be articulated retrospectively from an existing body of work. While it often appears early in exhibition planning, it may be revised as the exhibition takes shape.

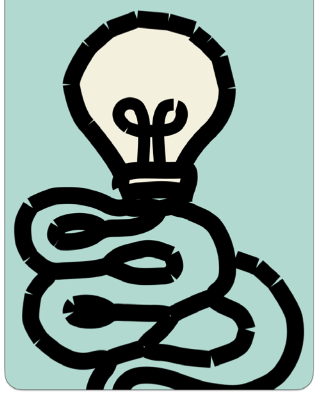
What it does
Establishes a shared inquiry that connects works without prescribing outcomes.

Guiding questions
- What question, tension, or condition connects these works?
- What is explicitly included or excluded?
- Who is the prompt written for: artists, audiences, or both?

Curatorial Prompt

The Exhibition Operations Kit

Interpretation Layer



The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
Interpretations are collective and iterative. Artists, curators, researchers, installers, audiences, (essentially all participants) may contribute to interpretation-making at multiple moments throughout the exhibition lifecycle.

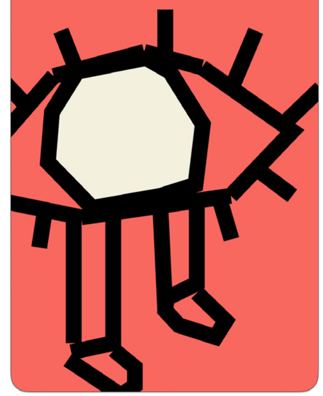
What it does
Shapes how meaning is scaffolded without fixing interpretation.

Guiding questions
- How do the decisions enhance or weaken the exhibition's inquiry?
- What contextual information is necessary, and what should remain open?
- Where does interpretation live: text, space, interaction, or instruction?

Interpretation Layer

The Exhibition Operations Kit

Experience Planning



The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
This process is collective and unfolds across planning stages, both before and after an exhibition site is identified. Experience planning continues as spatial constraints, technical conditions, and audience behaviors become known.

What it does
Designs the temporal, spatial, and sensory sequence of encounter.

Guiding questions
- Who is experiencing the exhibition, at what time, under what conditions?
- What actions, movements, or pauses happen in the exhibition?
- How do space, timing, and interaction shape the experience?

Experience Planning

The Exhibition Operations Kit

Peripheral & Artifacts

The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
Peripherals may be designed individually or collectively and can be introduced at any stage of the exhibition process.

What it does
Extends the exhibition beyond the gallery through materials that support access, memory, and circulation.

Guiding questions
- What can all participants (artists, curator, researchers, audiences) take, keep, or revisit after the exhibition?
- How is the exhibition documented or archived?
- What materials circulate beyond the exhibition space?

Peripheral & Artifacts

The Exhibition Operations Kit

Public Programming

The Exhibition Operations Kit

How it happens
Public programming may be developed individually or collectively and can occur before, during, or after the exhibition.

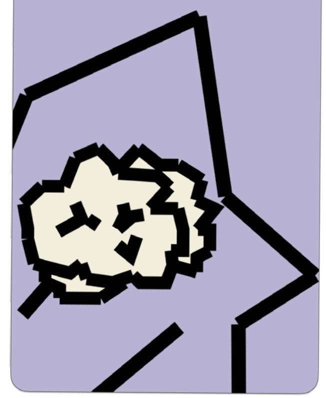
What it does
Activates the exhibition through events, conversations, or interventions.

Guiding questions
- How does the exhibition engage the communities it concerns?
- Who can speak, perform, or participate, and in what role?
- How does programming extend or challenge the exhibition's inquiry?

Public Programming

The Exhibition Operations Kit

Post Reflection



The Exhibition Operations Kit

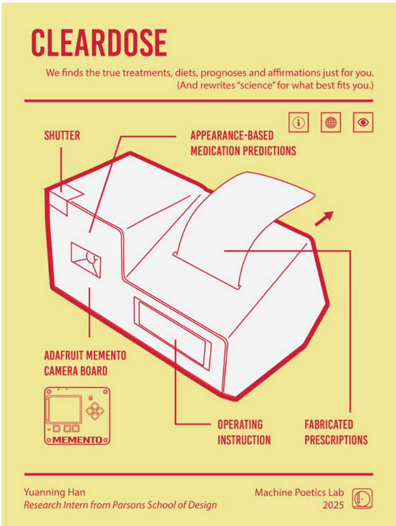
How it happens
This process is collective and iterative, occurring during and after the exhibition.

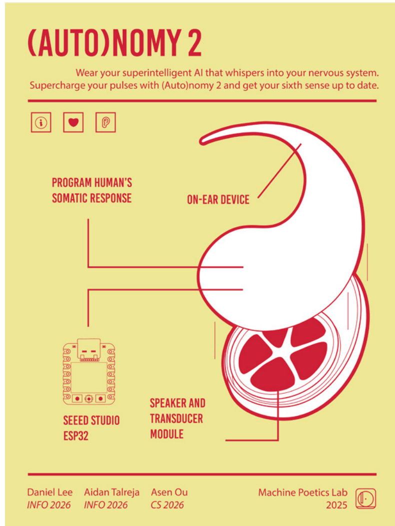
What it does
Consolidates learning from exhibition-making as research practice.

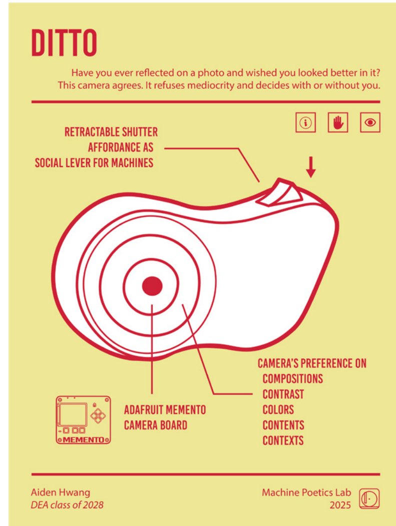
Guiding questions
- What was learned through staging this exhibition?
- What decisions led to unexpected outcomes or failures?
- How do these experiences inform future exhibitions, arts, researches or other type of projects?

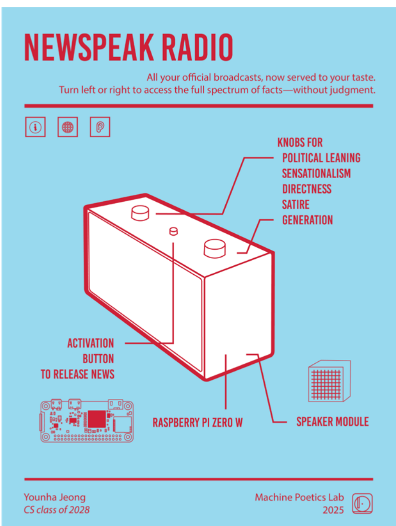
Post Reflection

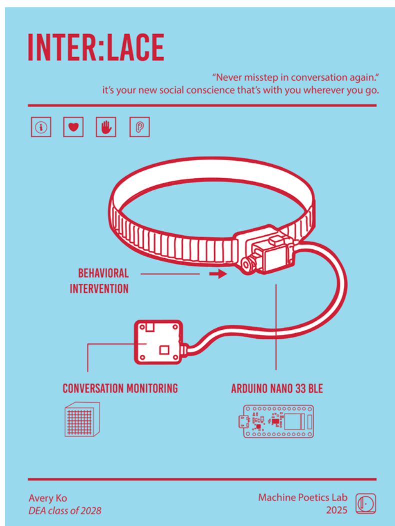
Appendix B: Perversion of Interfaces Posters

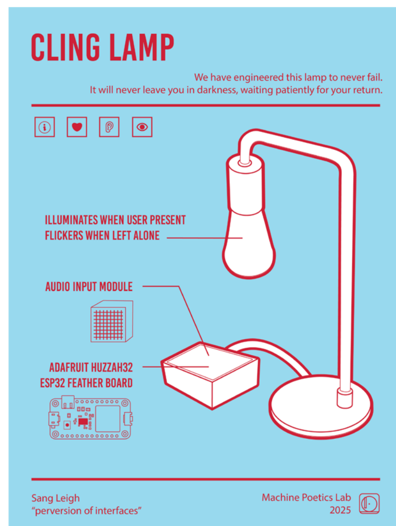


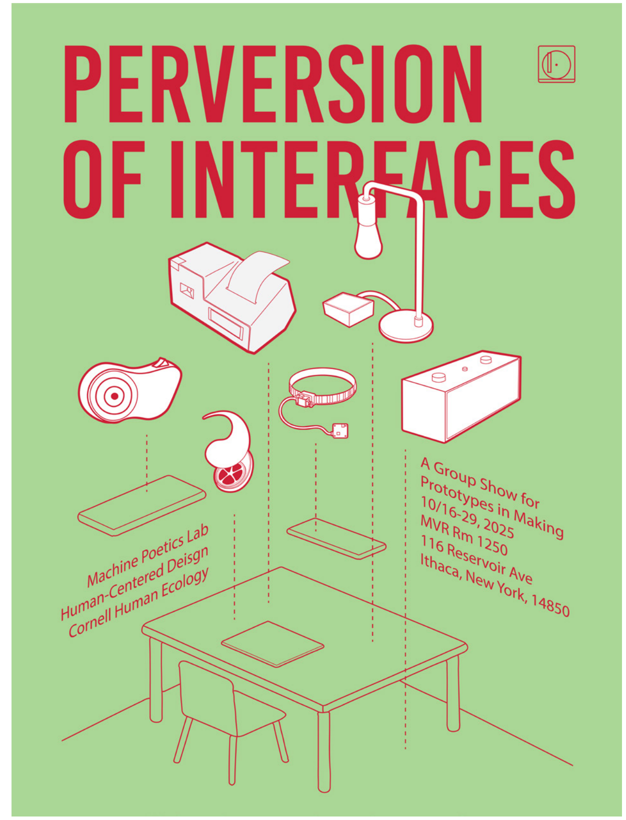


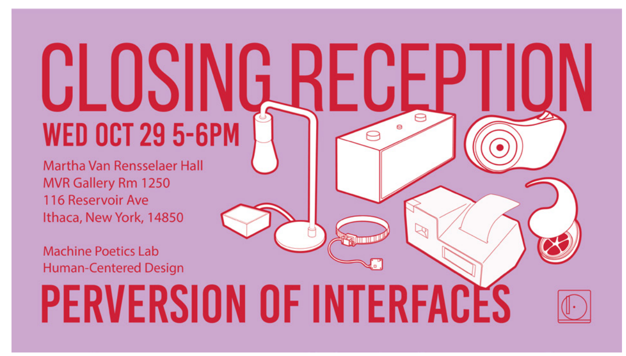












Appendix C: Perversion of Interfaces Coupons